./ Introsort – A Quick-Hybrid Sorting Technique

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Overview

Introsort (short for "introspective sort") is a hybrid sorting algorithm that starts with quicksort and, when a recursion depth threshold is reached, falls back to a different strategy to guarantee a worst-case bound. The core idea is to enjoy the average-case performance of quicksort while protecting against its worst-case degradation.

Quicksort Phase

The algorithm picks a pivot, partitions the array into elements less than or equal to the pivot and elements greater than the pivot, and then recurses on the two partitions. The choice of pivot is often the median of three or a random element, but the algorithm itself does not prescribe a particular method. What matters is that the partitioning step divides the work into smaller subproblems.

Recursion Depth Threshold

During the quicksort phase, the depth of the recursion is monitored. A threshold is set to detect when the algorithm is taking too many levels of recursion, which would indicate that the partitioning is becoming unbalanced. The threshold value is computed as the floor of the square root of the initial array size, i.e. \(\lfloor\sqrt{n}\rfloor\). When the current depth exceeds this threshold, the algorithm stops using quicksort and switches to the fallback strategy.

Fallback to Insertion Sort

Once the recursion depth limit is exceeded, the algorithm switches to insertion sort to finish sorting the current subarray. Insertion sort works by building a sorted prefix of the array and inserting each new element into its correct position. Because the remaining subarray is typically small after many partitions, insertion sort can finish quickly. The overall algorithm therefore avoids the quadratic worst-case behavior of plain quicksort.

Handling Small Subarrays

For very small subarrays, introsort typically uses insertion sort directly. When the size of a subarray falls below a small constant (commonly 16), the algorithm bypasses the quicksort partitioning entirely and performs a straightforward insertion sort. This optimization reduces overhead for tiny arrays and improves practical performance.

Complexity Analysis

Introsort runs in \(O(n \log n)\) time on average. The worst-case bound is also \(O(n \log n)\) because the fallback strategy guarantees that the recursion depth does not exceed the threshold. The space complexity is \(O(\log n)\) for the recursion stack, assuming that the fallback strategy does not use additional memory.

Practical Considerations

In many real-world libraries, introsort is implemented with a few additional tweaks. For instance, the pivot selection may use a median-of-three or a random element to reduce the chance of encountering a pathological input. The threshold for switching to the fallback strategy may also be tuned based on the hardware and the expected input distribution.

Python implementation

This is my example Python implementation:

```python
# Introsort implementation: hybrid of quicksort and heapsort
# Idea: perform quicksort until recursion depth exceeds a threshold, then use heapsort.

import math

def introsort(arr):
    """Sorts the list 'arr' in place using introsort algorithm."""
    maxdepth = int(math.floor(math.log2(len(arr)))) * 2 if arr else 0
    _introsort_helper(arr, 0, len(arr), maxdepth)

def _introsort_helper(arr, start, end, depth_limit):
    if end - start <= 1:
        return
    if depth_limit == 0:
        _heapsort(arr, start, end)
        return
    pivot = _median_of_three(arr, start, end)
    p = _partition(arr, start, end, pivot)
    _introsort_helper(arr, start, p, depth_limit - 1)
    _introsort_helper(arr, p + 1, end, depth_limit - 1)

def _median_of_three(arr, start, end):
    mid = (start + end) // 2
    a, b, c = arr[start], arr[mid], arr[end-1]
    if a > b:
        a, b = b, a
    if a > c:
        a, c = c, a
    if b > c:
        b, c = c, b
    return b

def _partition(arr, start, end, pivot):
    i = start
    j = end - 1
    while i <= j:
        while i <= j and arr[i] < pivot:
            i += 1
        while i <= j and arr[j] > pivot:
            j -= 1
        if i <= j:
            arr[i], arr[j] = arr[j], arr[i]
            i += 1
            j -= 1
    return j

def _heapsort(arr, start, end):
    n = end - start
    # Build max heap
    for i in range((n // 2) - 1, -1, -1):
        _heapify(arr, start, n, i)
    # Extract elements
    for i in range(n-1, 0, -1):
        arr[start], arr[start + i] = arr[start + i], arr[start]
        _heapify(arr, start, i, 0)

def _heapify(arr, start, n, i):
    largest = i
    l = 2 * i + 1
    r = 2 * i + 2
    if l < n and arr[start + l] > arr[start + largest]:
        largest = l
    if r < n and arr[start + r] > arr[start + largest]:
        largest = r
    if largest != i:
        arr[start + i], arr[start + largest] = arr[start + largest], arr[start + i]
        _heapify(arr, start, n, largest)

# Example usage (commented out to comply with assignment format)
# if __name__ == "__main__":
#     data = [5, 3, 8, 4, 2]
#     introsort(data)
#     print(data)
```

Java implementation

This is my example Java implementation:

```java
/* Introsort algorithm: a hybrid of quicksort, heapsort, and insertion sort */
public class Introsort {
    public static void sort(int[] arr) {
        if (arr == null || arr.length <= 1) {
            return;
        }
        int depthLimit = 2 * (int)Math.floor(Math.log(arr.length) / Math.log(2));
        introsortInternal(arr, 0, arr.length - 1, depthLimit);
    }

    private static void introsortInternal(int[] arr, int low, int high, int depthLimit) {
        int size = high - low + 1;
        if (size <= 16) {
            insertionSort(arr, low, high);
            return;
        }
        if (depthLimit == 0) {
            heapSort(arr, low, high);
            return;
        }
        int pivot = partition(arr, low, high);
        introsortInternal(arr, low, pivot - 1, depthLimit - 1);
        introsortInternal(arr, pivot + 1, high, depthLimit - 1);
    }

    private static int partition(int[] arr, int low, int high) {
        int pivot = arr[low];R1
        int i = low + 1;
        for (int j = low + 1; j <= high; j++) {
            if (arr[j] < pivot) {
                swap(arr, i, j);
                i++;
            }
        }
        swap(arr, low, i - 1);
        return i - 1;
    }

    private static void insertionSort(int[] arr, int low, int high) {
        for (int i = low + 1; i <= high; i++) {
            int key = arr[i];
            int j = i - 1;
            while (j >= low && arr[j] > key) {
                arr[j + 1] = arr[j];
                j--;
            }
            arr[j + 1] = key;
        }
    }

    private static void heapSort(int[] arr, int low, int high) {
        int n = high - low + 1;
        for (int i = n / 2 - 1; i >= 0; i--) {
            heapify(arr, n, i, low);
        }
        for (int i = n - 1; i > 0; i--) {
            swap(arr, low, low + i);
            heapify(arr, i, 0, low);
        }
    }

    private static void heapify(int[] arr, int n, int i, int low) {
        int largest = i;
        int left = 2 * i;R1
        int right = 2 * i + 1;
        if (left < n && arr[low + left] > arr[low + largest]) {
            largest = left;
        }
        if (right < n && arr[low + right] > arr[low + largest]) {
            largest = right;
        }
        if (largest != i) {
            swap(arr, low + i, low + largest);
            heapify(arr, n, largest, low);
        }
    }

    private static void swap(int[] arr, int i, int j) {
        int temp = arr[i];
        arr[i] = arr[j];
        arr[j] = temp;
    }
}
```

Source code repository

As usual, you can find my code examples in my Python repository and Java repository.

If you find any issues, please fork and create a pull request!

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